CONTEXT / CONTENT

DAEMONS

THE OLD WORD

How daimon branched, and why it is said DAY-mons

δαίμων





For release **v11.346.2**, 2026-11-11 · every word quoted from the game is a DRAFT
A fan project for the Game Boy Advance. No ROM is in it, or anywhere in DAEMONS.

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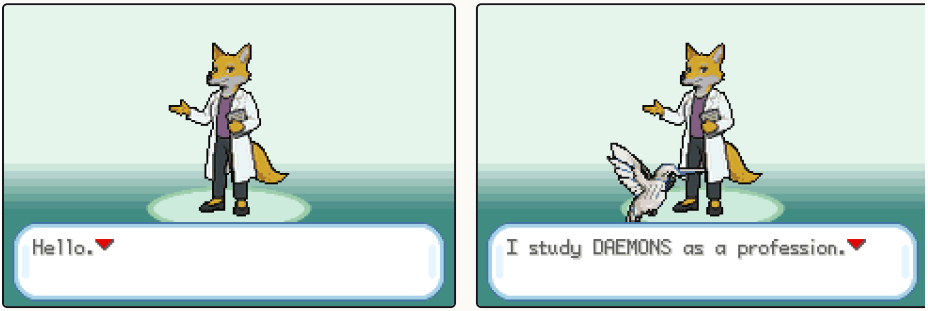
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CHAPTER 1

One word, two roads

The game is called **DAEMONS**, and it is said *DAY-mons*. This little book is about where that name comes from. It is a very old word, older than English and older than Latin, and on its long way to us it branched.



CRYSTAL CLEAR, who studies DAEMONS, says hello.

The rule of this book

Somewhere along the way, a **similarly spelt, frightening word** forked from the old one. It went its own way, and it is not the word this game is named for. This book tells the whole story, but it never prints that other word. When the story comes to it, it is called *the similarly spelt, frightening word*, or simply *the other word*, and that is enough.

Everything else here is real history. Where a fact comes from a book, the book is named at the back.

The map

Here is the whole journey on one page. Each chapter follows one stretch of it.



The old word's road, from the Greeks to this game. The grey branch is where the other word forked away.

CHAPTER 2

The Greeks: a spirit who gives each their share

The word

In ancient Greek the word was δαίμων -- *daimōn* -- and it sounded something like *DYE-mawn*, its voice rising on the first part. Where it came from is not certain, but the great Greek dictionary calls an old verb meaning *to divide, to hand out shares*, the likeliest root. A daimon, on that reading, is the one who allots each person their portion: their luck, their lot in life.

A power at work

In Homer's poems, a daimon is often a divine power felt at work in what happens -- a sudden courage, a stroke of luck, a spear that misses -- when nobody can say which god it was. Sometimes the word simply means a god.

Hesiod's golden people

The poet Hesiod, writing around 700 BCE, told of the ages of the world. The first people, he said, were a **golden race**, who lived without toil or old age. When they died, they did not vanish: they became *daimones* -- good ones, living on the earth, guardians of mortal people, and givers of wealth.

So, from the very beginning, a daimon could be a **guardian**.

Socrates' sign

The philosopher Socrates said he had a *daimonion* -- a small, divine something -- that had been with him since he was a child. It came as a voice. And it only ever said one thing: **not that**. It turned him back from a step he was about to take; it never pushed him forward.

At his trial in 399 BCE, Socrates noticed that the voice had not stopped him once that day. He took its silence as a sign that what was happening to him was not a bad thing.

Between gods and people

In Plato's *Symposium*, Socrates repeats what a wise woman, Diotima, once taught him: that Love -- Eros -- is not a god but **a great daimon**. Everything daimonic, she said, lives *between* gods and people. It carries prayers up and answers down, and fills the space between, so that the whole world holds together.

A good daimon

The Greek word for a happy, flourishing life is **eudaimonia**: *eu*, good, and *daimon*. To be happy was to have a good daimon. Aristotle made eudaimonia the highest good a person can reach.

CHAPTER 3

Rome: the daemon and the genius

Two letters for one sound

The Romans borrowed the word as **daemon**. The Greek *ai* became the Latin *ae* -- the two letters in the middle that this game keeps. In the Romans' own mouths, *ae* sounded much like the English word *eye*.

The genius

Rome already had a spirit of its own like the Greek one: the **genius**. Every Roman was thought to live, from the day they were born, under the care of their own, and each year on their birthday they gave it a gift. (A woman's was called her *juno*.) Our word *genius* comes from it.

Apuleius

In the second century, the writer Apuleius gave a lecture called *On the God of Socrates*. In it, daemons are the go-betweens: beings of the air, between the gods above and people below, carrying prayers up and gifts down. A person's own soul, he said, can itself be called

a daemon -- and in Latin, perhaps, a genius. And a higher kind of daemon is given to each person as a guardian and a witness, all their life.

A ladder of spirits

Later philosophers, the **Neoplatonists**, set out whole ladders of higher beings. One of them, Iamblichus, wrote of gods, archangels, angels, daimones, heroes, archons and souls, each with its own rung, each passing something down to the next.

CHAPTER 4

The fork

A word for the gods of others

In the third and second centuries BCE, in Alexandria, Jewish scholars translated their scriptures into Greek. That translation is called the *Septuagint*. In one psalm, where the Hebrew says that the gods of the nations are nothing, the Greek says that the gods of the nations are *daimonia* -- the old word, in its small form.

It was a small choice, and it changed the word. In the Christian writings that followed, the same small form named the unclean spirits that trouble people.

Augustine answers Apuleius

In the early 400s, Augustine of Hippo wrote *The City of God*. In it he answered Apuleius: there were no kindly go-betweens, he argued, and the beings Apuleius called daemons were not good at all. In Christian Latin, the word came to mean only that.

The other word

In the Middle Ages, Latin scribes usually wrote the *ae* as a plain *e*. With that, the frightening meaning had a spelling of its own: the **similarly spelt, frightening word**. It came into English around 1200, spelt the shorter way.

This is the fork. From here, the other word goes its own way, and this book does not follow it.

The old spelling, kept

But the old word was not lost. People who read the Greeks still needed a word for what the Greeks had meant -- a guardian, a guiding spirit, Socrates' voice -- and from the 1560s English writers used the word again in that old sense. To keep the two apart, it is often written the old way: **daemon**, with its *ae* -- or *daimon*, straight from the Greek.

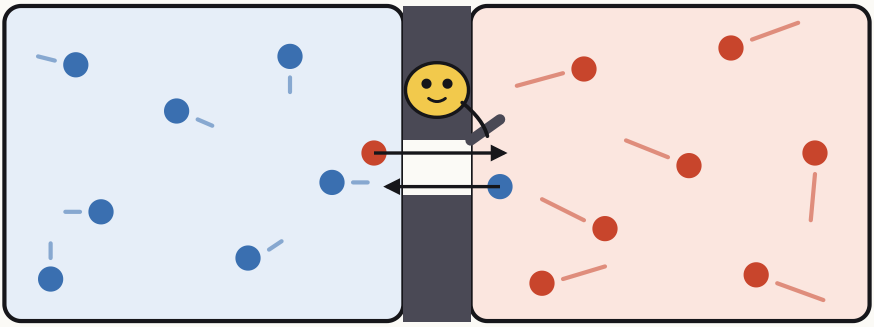
CHAPTER 5

Maxwell's sorting being

A puzzle in a letter

In December 1867, the Scottish physicist **James Clerk Maxwell** wrote to his friend Peter Guthrie Tait with a puzzle. Heat, as everyone knew, flows from warm things to cool ones, never the other way, unless someone does work to push it. But what if there were a being -- "a very observant and neat-fingered being", he called it -- quick enough to follow single molecules?

Put a gas in two rooms, with a wall between them and a tiny door. The being watches. When a **fast** molecule comes up to the door from the left, it opens it and lets it through; when a **slow** one comes from the right, it lets that one through the other way. Nothing else gets past.



the slow ones
this side grows cooler

the fast ones
this side grows warmer

and nobody seems to have done any work

Maxwell's sorting being at its door. The fast ones gather on one side and the slow on the other.

Little by little, one side grows warm and the other cool -- and the being seems to have done no work at all. Maxwell put the puzzle in his book *Theory of Heat* in 1871.

Its name

Maxwell called it a *being*. In 1874, the physicist **William Thomson** -- later Lord Kelvin -- gave it the name most people know it by, in the journal *Nature*, and that name is the other word. Maxwell did

not choose it. In a note to Tait, he asked who gave them that name, answered *Thomson*, and suggested calling the being no such thing: just a **valve**.

Some writers spell it *Maxwell's daemon*, with the old spelling, and so does this book.

The answer

The puzzle took about a century to answer, and people still argue over the answer. Leo Szilárd (1929) said the being pays when it *measures* which molecules are fast. Rolf Landauer (1961) showed that *erasing* a single bit of memory always costs a little energy. And Charles Bennett (1982) showed that the measuring can be done for free -- but to keep sorting, the being must sooner or later forget what it knew, to make room. Forgetting costs energy. The sorting is paid for after all, in memory.

CHAPTER 6

Helpers in the background

Project MAC

At the Massachusetts Institute of Technology in the early 1960s, **Fernando Corbató** and his team built CTSS: one of the first systems that let many people use one computer at once. From 1 July 1963 their work went on as part of MIT's **Project MAC**.

They wrote programs that ran by themselves, in the background, doing the computer's chores -- with no one at a keyboard to ask them. Corbató wrote later that the name came from Maxwell's sorting being, which had worked tirelessly in the background too. They called the programs **daemons**. The programmers' own dictionary, the *Jargon File*, says the very first was a program that copied the files onto tape, to keep them safe.

Unix, and the d

The word went with the programmers. In **Unix**, and the systems that grew from it, which much of the internet still runs on, a daemon is any program that runs in the background -- and by

custom its name often ends in a **d**.

what runs in the background

```
sshd       waits for a knock, and lets them in
crond      keeps the clock's appointments
syslogd    writes down what happened
httpd      hands out web pages
```

The d at the end of each name is for daemon.
Each one runs by itself, without being asked.

A few of the daemons in a computer today, and what each one does.

Some people say *daemon* stands for *Disk And Execution MONitor*. It does not: the *Jargon File* calls that a later invention, a backronym. The name came from Maxwell, and before him from the Greeks.

CHAPTER 7

DAEMONS

One word, both meanings

So the game's name carries both of the old word's lives: the Greeks' **guiding spirit**, who keeps you company and hands you your share, and the programmers' **helper**, who runs by itself in the background.



GUARDIAN · LODESTAR · CRON · HEARTBEAT

A few of the game's DAEMONS.

How to say it

In English, *daemon* is said more than one way, and programmers have long said *DAY-mon* (the *Jargon File* gives it). This game says it *DAY-mons*: nearer the Greeks' *DYE-mawn*, and nothing like the other word.

CHAPTER 8

Where it comes from

Hesiod, *Works and Days*, lines 109-126: the golden race, and the daimones they became.

Homer, *Iliad* 1.222: Athena goes back to Olympus, among the other daimones.

Plato, *Apology* 31c-d and 40a-c: Socrates' sign. *Symposium* 202d-203a: Diotima on Eros, a great daimon.

Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, Book I: eudaimonia.

Apuleius, *On the God of Socrates* (*De deo Socratis*), chapters 6 and 15-16: the go-betweens, the soul as genius, and the guardian.

Censorinus, *On the Birthday* (*De die natali*), 2-3: the genius, and its birthday gift.

Iamblichus, *On the Mysteries* (*De mysteriis*), Book II: the orders of higher beings.

The Septuagint, Psalm 95:5 (96:5 in the Hebrew numbering); the New Testament's *daimonion*.

Augustine, *The City of God*, Books 8-9 (9.19 on the word's one meaning in scripture).

James Clerk Maxwell, letter to P. G. Tait, 11 December 1867, and his undated note to Tait on the name, both in C. G. Knott, *Life and Scientific Work of Peter Guthrie Tait* (1911); *Theory of Heat* (1871), pages 308-309.

William Thomson, "Kinetic Theory of the Dissipation of Energy", *Nature* 9 (1874), 441-444.

Leo Szilárd (1929), **Rolf Landauer** (1961), **Charles H. Bennett** (1982); and O. Maroney, "Information Processing and Thermodynamic Entropy", *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*: what the sorting costs.

Fernando J. Corbató, letter in *Take Our Word For It*, issue 146 (2002).

The Jargon File, version 4.4.8, "daemon". **Etymonline**, "daimon". **Liddell, Scott and Jones**, *A Greek-English Lexicon*, "δαίμων".

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